BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

My treatment, tests and checks

Source-required blood tests are distinguished from tests ordered for a particular symptom or disease plan. Imaging is not interchangeable with blood safety tests.

Check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Phase / dose review	After treatment
Blood and organ tests	Blood count, kidney and liver function with electrolytes, magnesium and calcium. Review allergies, previous reactions, red-meat allergy or tick bites. Before head and neck radiation, arrange dental, nutrition and swallowing assessment with the team.	Blood count, kidney/liver function and minerals are reviewed regularly as specified in the treatment plan. Vitals and symptoms are checked around infusions; skin, eyes, breathing and hydration are reviewed. Radiation has its own weekly support and assessment plan.	Contact the team if symptoms develop; extra tests may be needed before the next visit.	Recheck relevant results after a hold or changed plan; previous toxicity remains relevant.	Electrolytes, magnesium and calcium monthly for two months after the final cetuximab dose. Continue skin, dental, nutrition, swallowing and radiation follow-up. Scans and examinations follow the individual cancer plan; no universal scan date or tumour-marker test is required by this regimen.
Radiotherapy	Planning appointment and separate radiation calendar.	Cetuximab begins one week before radiation, then continues weekly until radiation ends.	Attend radiation on its own calendar; no assumption of weekend sessions.	Coordinate interruptions and recovery between both teams.	Late effects and response follow-up belong to the radiation plan.
Treatment and appointments	Confirm the exact diagnosis, intent, prescription and calendar.	The first cetuximab infusion runs over 120 minutes; later infusions usually run over 60 minutes. Premedication and observation add to visit time. Your team confirms the observation period; no early discharge is promised after two doses.	Use the prescribed support plan and contact route.	National Cancer Control Programme (NCCP) specifies monthly electrolytes, magnesium and calcium for two months after the final cetuximab dose; continue mouth, skin, swallowing and nutrition care as needed.	Record the final dose and follow-up appointments.
Eating, mouth and swallowing	Agree oral care and assess weight, intake and swallowing; arrange dental review before head/neck radiation.	Review pain, weight, hydration and safe swallowing.	Report poor intake, choking, weight loss or inability to drink promptly.	Dietitian and speech/language plans adapt to symptoms and recovery.	Continue dental, nutritional and swallowing follow-up as needed.
Imaging and tumour assessment	Confirm staging and any relevant tumour tests; these are distinct from blood safety tests.	Discuss symptoms and treatment response.	The team arranges scans or examinations when indicated.	Use the agreed assessment to guide the next phase.	Record scan and clinic dates; this regimen does not impose a single timetable for everyone.

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00207 v6: official regimen

Tests in your plan

Full blood count, kidneys and liver

WHEN

Baseline and regularly during treatment

Support safe treatment and identify problems needing review.

Electrolytes, magnesium and calcium

WHEN

Monitor during treatment; monthly for two months after the last dose.

Checks a medicine-specific risk that symptoms alone may miss.

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

Weekly cetuximab + head and neck radiotherapy: treatment and checks

Locally advanced squamous head and neck cancer in people ineligible for platinum-based treatment.

Cetuximab starts one week before radiotherapy: a 400 mg/m² first infusion, then 250 mg/m² every week during radiation until radiotherapy ends. The number of weekly doses follows the actual radiotherapy plan.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Phase / dose review	After treatment
Blood and organ tests NCCP	Blood count, kidney and liver function with electrolytes, magnesium and calcium. Review allergies, previous reactions, red-meat allergy or tick bites. Before head and neck radiation, arrange dental, nutrition and swallowing assessment with the team.	Blood count, kidney/liver function and minerals are reviewed regularly as specified in the treatment plan. Vitals and symptoms are checked around infusions; skin, eyes, breathing and hydration are reviewed. Radiation has its own weekly support and assessment plan.	Contact the team if symptoms develop; extra tests may be needed before the next visit.	Recheck relevant results after a hold or changed plan; previous toxicity remains relevant.	Electrolytes, magnesium and calcium monthly for two months after the final cetuximab dose. Continue skin, dental, nutrition, swallowing and radiation follow-up. Scans and examinations follow the individual cancer plan; no universal scan date or tumour-marker test is required by this regimen.
Radiotherapy NCCP	Planning appointment and separate radiation calendar.	Cetuximab begins one week before radiation, then continues weekly until radiation ends.	Attend radiation on its own calendar; no assumption of weekend sessions.	Coordinate interruptions and recovery between both teams.	Late effects and response follow-up belong to the radiation plan.
Treatment and appointments NCCP	Confirm the exact diagnosis, intent, prescription and calendar.	The first cetuximab infusion runs over 120 minutes; later infusions usually run over 60 minutes. Premedication and observation add to visit time. Your team confirms the observation period; no early discharge is promised after two doses.	Use the prescribed support plan and contact route.	NCCP specifies monthly electrolytes, magnesium and calcium for two months after the final cetuximab dose; continue mouth, skin, swallowing and nutrition care as needed.	Record the final dose and follow-up appointments.
Eating, mouth and swallowing NCCP	Agree oral care and assess weight, intake and swallowing; arrange dental review before head/neck radiation.	Review pain, weight, hydration and safe swallowing.	Report poor intake, choking, weight loss or inability to drink promptly.	Dietitian and speech/language plans adapt to symptoms and recovery.	Continue dental, nutritional and swallowing follow-up as needed.

Care / check	Before starting	Treatment visit	Between visits	Phase / dose review	After treatment
Imaging and tumour assessment NCCP	Confirm staging and any relevant tumour tests; these are distinct from blood safety tests.	Discuss symptoms and treatment response.	The team arranges scans or examinations when indicated.	Use the agreed assessment to guide the next phase.	Record scan and clinic dates; this regimen does not impose a single timetable for everyone.

What each check is for

1 Cetuximab before radiotherapy

One week before radiation

Cetuximab is combined with radiotherapy for selected locally advanced head and neck cancer when platinum chemotherapy is unsuitable. The team discusses the reason for choosing this treatment and the alternatives.

Ask / act: Confirm the current phase, prescription, tests and support plan.

Sources: NCCP

2 Weekly cetuximab with radiotherapy

Weekly until radiation ends

Cetuximab is combined with radiotherapy for selected locally advanced head and neck cancer when platinum chemotherapy is unsuitable. The team discusses the reason for choosing this treatment and the alternatives.

Ask / act: Confirm the current phase, prescription, tests and support plan.

Sources: NCCP

3 Recovery and mineral checks

After the last dose

Cetuximab is combined with radiotherapy for selected locally advanced head and neck cancer when platinum chemotherapy is unsuitable. The team discusses the reason for choosing this treatment and the alternatives.

Ask / act: Confirm the current phase, prescription, tests and support plan.

Sources: NCCP

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Sources checked 2026-11-07 · Source reconciled draft; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending · SACTCheck v0.84.45